have to accept China not giving up its close relationship with Pakistan and other South Asian nations and improving the Sino–Indian relationship regardless of the border dispute. Three weeks before Foreign Minister Huang Hua landed in New Delhi in June 1981, China's Premier Zhao Ziyang visited Pakistan, Nepal, and Bangladesh to convey the message that improving relations with India would not come at the expense of their respective friendships.[55] By the end of the 1980s, however, China's influence in Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh was still limited, and Pakistan remained China's only close collaborator in the region.[56]

It is difficult to judge to what extent China looked at its effort at improving relations with India as a wedge strategy aimed at the Soviet Union. First, China continued a relatively confrontational policy vis-à-vis India, and second, from the early 1980s, it was the efforts in Beijing and Moscow to improve Sino–Soviet relations that opened space also for closer Sino–Indian ties.[57] Normalisation of Sino–Soviet relations reduced Beijing's concern for Soviet–India collusion in South Asia,[58] and Moscow "disengaged from its alliance with India to help open the door to rapprochement with Beijing."[59] During his visit to India in November 1986, Gorbachev reassured India that warming relations with China would not lead to weakening Soviet support to India, but during the same visit, Gorbachev refused to take India's side in its border dispute with China (ibid). Hosting India's Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi for talks in Beijing during his landmark visit to China in December 1988, Deng Xiaoping emphasised that China and India should find common ground in working together for the interest of developing countries and work less in service of the rich Western countries.[60] However, this policy would be implemented only to a certain degree.